

1753



Based on the work of the botanist Carl Linnaeus, this botanical drawing of blackberries is by J. Miller.

BY THE TIME SIR HANS SLOANE (1660–1753), an Irish-born physician and collector, died, he had amassed 71,000 different objects, ranging from samples of flora and fauna from all over the world, to books and manuscripts about a wide range of subjects. Like other intellectuals and scientists across Europe, he was part of wider Enlightenment intellectual currents, and he had realized the scholarly value of his collection, which he bequeathed to Britain. In

Golden collection
Used for determining positions of stars, this gold astrolabe, was part of Hans Sloane's collection.

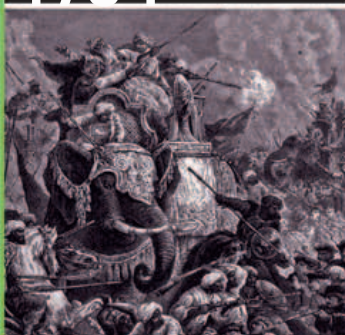
exchange, he wanted a payment of £20,000 to his estate – well below the value of the collection. The English Parliament approved the deal and passed an act establishing the **British Museum**. Parts of the collection were put on public display a few years later.

Sloane's contemporaries across Europe were engaged in collecting and other scientific pursuits.

In the same year, Swedish botanist **Carl Linnaeus** (1707–78) published his *Species Plantarum*, which classified more than 7,000 species of plants by putting each genus into a class and order, a system that is still used today.

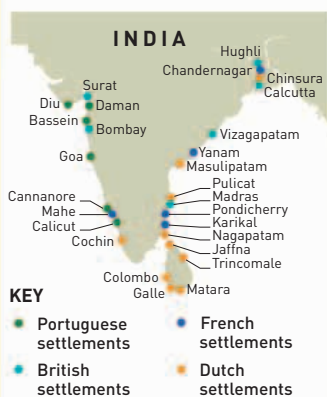


1754



This scene shows troops mounted on elephants during the Carnatic War.

THE SECOND CARNATIC WAR (1749–54) and the **French and Indian War** (1754–63) were both precursors to the larger **Seven Years' War** (1756–63). However, the theatre of these Anglo-French disputes was not Europe. The



Europe in India
By the mid-18th century, European powers held territories and established settlements in India.

French and Indian War ranged from Virginia in the south to Nova Scotia in the north of North America. Battles of the **Second Carnatic War** took place in South India. The **Treaty of Pondicherry** temporarily halted tensions between France and Britain, whose troops were technically employed by corporations – the **East India companies**. The treaty recognized the British-backed Mohammad Ali as the new **Nawab of Carnatic**, which had been a key factor behind the dispute.

1755



A painting depicts the desperate search for survivors in Lisbon after the city was heavily damaged by an earthquake in November.

“ I AM NOT SO LOST IN LEXICOGRAPHY AS TO FORGET THAT WORDS ARE THE DAUGHTERS OF EARTH. ”

Samuel Johnson, English writer, from the preface of his *Dictionary of the English Language*, 1755

AN EARTHQUAKE KILLED TENS OF THOUSANDS OF PEOPLE in Lisbon, Portugal, when it shook the city on the morning of 1 November. It was later estimated by scientists to be around an 8.7 magnitude event. Estimates of the number of deaths range from 10,000 to 100,000 in a population of 200,000. The earthquake also triggered a tsunami that destroyed settlements further south in the Algarve region. The disaster had a profound effect across Europe – **Voltaire** (1694–1778) was inspired to write his *Poème sur le désastre de Lisbonne* about the event, and German philosopher Immanuel Kant (1724–1804) wrote a series of essays about it. The **Marquis of Pombal** (see panel, left) immediately took action, making sure fires were put out and the dead were quickly buried. He then began the rebuilding of the city, including the construction of buildings meant to withstand another earthquake.

Earlier in the year, in England, the writer **Samuel Johnson** (1709–84) had completed the commission he had received for a **Dictionary of the English Language** from a syndicate of

London printers. It took him eight years and six assistants to finish it. Although it was not the first English dictionary, it quickly became the most celebrated and authoritative. Some of its more notorious definitions include “patron: commonly a wretch who supports with insolence, and is paid with flattery” and “oats: a grain, which in England is generally given to horses, but in Scotland supports the people”.



English by definition
This is the front cover of the first edition of Samuel Johnson's *Dictionary of the English Language*.

March Sweden adopts Gregorian calendar

April 5 Founding charter of British Museum is enacted

Carl Linnaeus publishes his *Species Plantarum*

The **French and Indian War** between Britain and France and its Indian allies begins

Treaty of Pondicherry ends Second Carnatic war

Scottish chemist and physicist **Joseph Black** (1728–99) discovers carbon dioxide

The British drive French settlers out of **Acadia** (now part of Canada)

April 15 Samuel Johnson publishes his ground-breaking English-language dictionary

November 1 Violent earthquake devastates Lisbon